Three Stories, One Family

Presented by Mary Smith

Three Stories, One Family highlights the brutal systems that destroy whole families without any accountability.

Eileen Smith, her eldest son Christopher (Christy) Smith and daughter Mary Smith, lived through hardship in mother and baby homes, Magdalene Laundries, and Industrial Schools.

Eventually, both Eileen and Christy lost their lives in Mental Asylums after facing years of ongoing cruelty.

Eileen Smith
The Unknown Story

Mary Smith, daughter of Eileen Smith, has spent years tracing down her mother and brother, Christy Smith. There is very little information been given and there is much more to know. What Mary managed to piece together is written here.

After Christy's birth, Eileen and her baby were sentenced to Bessborough Mother and Baby Home in Blackrock, Cork, where they remained for approximately three years until Mary's grandmother succeeds in getting them released and brought home to Newmarket, Co. Cork. While in Newmarket, a young and health Christopher (Christy) Smith school and was reportedly a happy child who had many friends.

The situation changed dramatically when Eileen became pregnant for the second time with Mary. According to the admission records Mary later pieced together, a local priest (Fr. D. G. McCabe) came to the family home and ordered that Eileen be removed because she was pregnant outside of marriage. This time, Eileen was sentenced to the Magdalene Laundry in Peacock Lane, Co. Cork by court order.

Mary Smith was born on 15 July 1952 at Fermoy Hospital, Co. Cork. Her birth certificate, discovered much later, confirmed that her mother was Eileen Smith of Kerry Road, Newmarket, Co. Cork.

There had been no record of Mary for the first two years of her life, up until she entered a system defined by cruelty.

Bessborough Mother and Baby home was run by the Sisters of Mercy. An admission certificate later discovered confirmed Mary had been brought to the school by Fr. D. G. McCabe.

Mary’s Story

Mary's mother already had a son, Christopher (Christy) Smith, who had been born a few years earlier.

This is Mary's story of finding her mother buried in a mass grave and never getting to know how and why her mother died, and finding out some 40 years later, she had a brother who suffered abuse in the industrial schools of Ireland, and later spending the rest of his life incarcerated in a mental asylum because he was homeless. Christy died a tragic death. There has been no accountability for the abuse suffered while in the industrial schools or from the psychiatrist responsible for his care. Mary herself spent the early years in an industrial school and a Magdalene laundry before breaking away from the cruelty that stole her family.

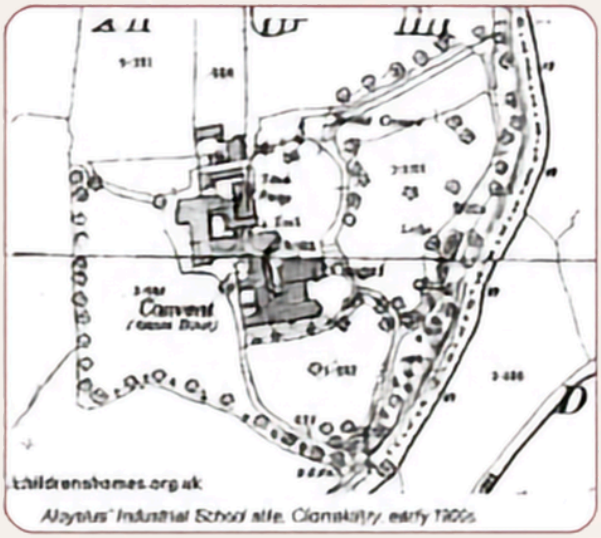
This is their story.

Mary Smith

2001

The Industrial Schools

Mary describes her early years in St. Aloysius Industrial School in Clonakilty as a period of relentless labour and harsh discipline. The girls were not treated as children and were rarely allowed to attend school classes. Instead they were made to work constantly. They were frequently beaten by the nuns and repeatedly told they were worthless. Birthdays, Christmas, and other normal aspects of childhood did not exist for them. They were not allowed to keep their birth names and the girls were identified by numbers. Mary's number was 1364.



Aloysius' Industrial School site, Clonakilty, early 1900s

After spending many years in Clonakilty, Mary remembers the arrival of a man known to the children as "the cruelty man." His name was William O'Callaghan, an officer with the Irish Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Children (ISPCC). Mary recalls the day when six girls, including Mary, were lined up with their small suitcases and placed into O'Callaghan's black Volkswagen van.

They were transported to St. Joseph's Industrial School in Mallow, Co Cork. Not having any concepts of birthdays, Mary didn't know her exact age, but believes it would have been somewhere between fourteen and sixteen years,

Mary remained at St. Joseph's in Mallow for approximately two years. She recalls that conditions there were somewhat less severe than in Clonakilty, but she still did not receive a formal education and continued to live under institutional control.

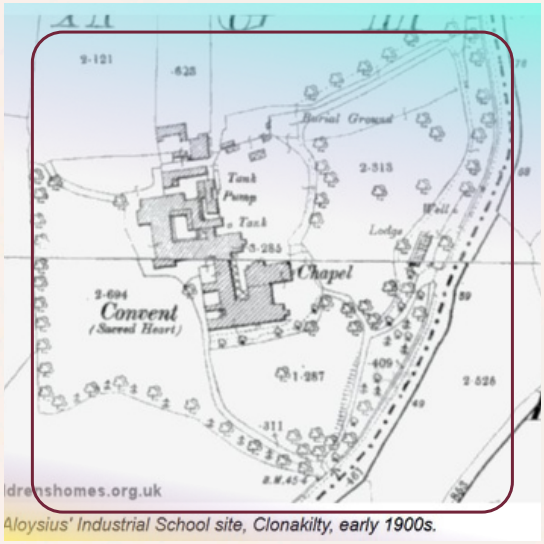
The Early Years

Mary's early childhood soon became defined by institutionalisation. There are no records of Mary for the first two years of her life.

On 15 May 1954, when she was approximately two and a half years old, Mary was sentenced by court to St. Aloysius Industrial School for Girls in Clonakilty, County Cork.

Mary discovered years later from a man named Dennis McCarty that her mother had been raped and that Dennis knew the man who had allegedly raped her, although Dennis would not say who at the time. Years later, DNA tests confirmed that it was one of Dennis McCarthy's brothers who lived next door to the Smith family in Newmarket. This information gave Mary a new understanding of how her mother came to be pregnant with her and also identified her father. The brother of Dennis McCarthy, had died just two years earlier.

Mary has no knowledge of how her mother came to be in a mental institution after Mary was born, or how she died, or why she was buried in a mass grave.



Aloysius' Industrial School site, Clonakilty, early 1900s.

The institution was run by the Sisters of Mercy. An admission certificate later discovered, confirmed Mary had been brought to the school by Fr. D. G. McCabe.

A Romantic Liaison

During her time in Mallow, Mary met a young man named Thomas Donovan. The two became close friends and eventually spoke about marriage. For Mary, this romantic liaison represented the first time she had ever experienced affection or a sense of belonging. However, the relationship was soon discovered by those overseeing her.

As Mary got older, arrangements were made for her to work in the home of Mr. and Mrs. Jim O'Keefe, wealthy industrialists connected with iron refineries. The arrangement had been organised by William O'Callaghan and Mrs. O'Keefe, on his recommendation. Mrs O'Keefe had repeatedly come to the industrial school requesting Mary as a domestic worker for her household.

Mary agreed to take the opportunity because she believed it might offer a chance to escape the industrial school. However, conditions in the house were extremely harsh. When she arrived, Mrs. O'Keefe immediately forced her to kneel on a cold floor in a white coat and scrub it. Mary worked from eight in the morning until late at night, performing domestic labour. She was not permitted to use the family's bathroom and was forced to relieve herself outside in the yard. She was repeatedly told she was "a slave, a nobody" and only "an orphan" and she "amounted to nothing."

During her time there, O'Callaghan would turn up at the O'Keefe's home. He'd sit in the big sitting room and tell Mary such things as, "you're getting more like your mother every day - big chested, just like your mother."

Thomas Donovan meanwhile, had been trying to find Mary, even going to the industrial school looking for her. After discovering Mary was working for the O'Keefe's, Thomas began writing letters to her. He also travelled from Mallow to Cork to meet her on one occasion. Thomas had given her a small photo of himself, but that was taken from her. That photo meant everything to Mary giving her hope of finding a relationship and real love.

Thomas continued writing letters to Mary, until one day, Mrs. O'Keefe intercepted his correspondence and contacted O'Callaghan who immediately transported Mary to the Good Shepherd's Sundays Well Magdalene Laundry in Co Cork for no other reason than, Mary "might" get pregnant.

The Assault

Upon arriving at the Magdelene Laundry, the experience left Mary utterly devastated and in despair, even wanting to die, and feeling that once the doors were closed behind her she may never come out again. She was never to see Thomas again, until 2004, when they met up by chance. Thomas revealed that he had never gotten over Mary but their lives had now taken different paths.

Mary remained in the laundry for 10 months before she was returned to the O'Keefe's household where she stayed for a further 3 months. When Mrs O'Keefe spotted Mary being friendly and speaking to a delivery man, she contacted O'Callaghan again and accused Mary of "chatting up men."

O'Callaghan arrived in his black Volkswagen van and removed Mary from the O'Keefe's household. She did not know where she was being taken to and only had thoughts of being sent back to the Laundry. At one point when the van stopped, Mary seized the opportunity to escape, opening the door and running. O'Callaghan chased after her, caught her and knocked her to the ground. He pulled off her blue tights and she describes how he sexually assaulted her right there on the ground. At the time, having had no understanding of sex, Mary didn't fully comprehend what was happening.

After the assault, O'Callaghan dragged Mary back to the vehicle and was driving her to the Santa Maria Hostel in Mountain Mardyke, Co. Cork. During the journey, O'Callaghan warned her that if there were no rooms at the hostel he would have no choice but to send her to the local mental institution. He spoke about Mary's mother Eileen, how her mother had never been given a chance and that he wanted to give Mary a chance. Mary distraught, demanded to know how he knew her mother and where was her mother? O'Callaghan responded coldly, "She's dead." "How do you know my mother is dead," Mary demanded. "Because I was around her when she died," he answered. Mary later discovered that her mother had actually died in 1964. Cause of death, unknown and buried in a mass grave.

Mary was incredibly fortunate to find a room at the hostel and was relieved to be allowed to stay. However, her relief was short-lived as she discovered that the hostel was set to close in just two weeks. When it finally shut down, Mary found herself homeless, with nowhere to turn. Forced to sleep rough on the streets, she faced a relentless struggle, never knowing where she would find shelter next.

Mary Discovers She has a Brother

Sometime later, Mary managed to secure employment at the Bon Secours Hospital, where she worked as a cook responsible for preparing meals for approximately 150 people. She was working at Bon Secour when she received a call from Anne Fahy, a former student of St. Aylosius Industrial School. Anne was now living in Dublin and persuaded Mary to come to live in Dublin together with her and her partner.

When Mary reported to Anne, inappropriate behaviour from Anne's partner, Mary was asked to leave abruptly. She remained in Dublin and obtained employment at the Smith's Crisps factory in a quality-control role. Mr Clark, the manager overseeing her work, is surprised by her aptitude and asks Mary which college had she attended, unaware that Mary had never received any formal education.

It was around this time, Mary also found, tucked away in her little suitcase, her own birth certificate. She believed it had been put there by Mrs. O'Keefe. The birth certificate listed an Eileen Smith, as Mary's mother and Eileen was listed as living at Kerry Road, Newmarket, Co. Cork. Believing she may find her mother alive, Mary now felt deeply committed to finding her family.

While working at the Smith's Crisps factory, Mary became friends with a colleague named Gillian O'Sullivan, who was travelling back and forth regularly from Dublin to Fermoy, Co. Cork. After returning one weekend, Gillian tells Mary, a lady living beside her in Fermoy is Francis Daly. Francis Daly's mother is Nora May O'Leary who lives 40 miles away in Newmarket. Nora May lived next door to the Smiths and Nora May went to school with Eileen Smith, Mary's mother.

Gillian also brings back the news that Mary has an elder brother, and his name is Christopher (Christy) Smith.

She immediately visits Newmarket where she met with Nora May O'Leary. Nora May spoke of how she and Eileen would go to school together. She told Mary how very much like her mother Mary was. Nora May told the story of how she and Mary's grandmother went up to the Magdalene Laundry to try and get Eileen out. The nuns told them that Eileen was a sinner and she would pay for her penance. They threatened that if either one of them came back, they would put Eileen somewhere else. That's the last Nora May saw of Mary's mother.

Finding a Birth Certificate

She wrote to the local priest in Newmarket but was grief stricken by the response. The priest's words where harsh, "That woman is dead and don't write back here again." Mary's hopes of finding out more about her mother were crushed and out of anger she tore up the letter and flushed it down the toilet.

Christopher (Christy) Smith and Mary Smith, 2001

Mary was angry with the response from the priest, but had now become very suspicious. She visited Joy's House, the registrar's office that hold records of all births and deaths. At Joy's House, she was shown a large register of the surname Smith. When the file was opened, the name Christopher Smith of Cork appeared immediately on the first page and within minutes Mary had her brother's birth certificate in hand.

Mary decided to write to the priest in Newmarket again, this time wanting to find out more information about Christopher Smith. The priest wrote back, "your brother is dead."

He then listed all the people in the Smith family he knew. Mary was devastated, believing all her family had perished.

After leaving Joy's House with certificate in hand, Mary encountered, by chance, the well-known broadcaster Gerry Ryan. She approached him and explained that she was trying to find her brother. Ryan was interested in her story, and advised Mary to contact his researcher Joan Tosney, which eventually led to Mary telling her story on RTE radio. After the show, Dennis McCarthy calls in and tells Gerry Ryan that the McCarthys lived next door to the Smiths in Newmarket. Dennis later speaks to Mary, and tells her he knows the man who raped her mother. But it wasn't until 2019, when Mary confirms, through DNA tests, that it was one of the McCarthy brothers that had raped Eileen and he was in fact, Mary's father. Which brother was never named.

Following the radio show, Joan and Mary travelled to Cork in an effort to locate more information about Christy. Joan had arranged a meeting with Raymond O'Sullivan who had gone to school with Christy. Raymond confirmed Christy was well liked at school and got on well with the other kids. He told Mary, Christy was sent to an Industrial School for stealing sweets. After the meeting, Raymond calls Joan back and informs her of a chance meeting he just had with a woman who was working at the Our Lady's Mental Asylum on Lee Road, Co. Cork and she tells Raymond that there is a man that fits Christy's description at the hospital. Raymond advises Joan however, not to tell Mary as it may be distressing for her.

Mary Smith & Brother Christopher (Christy), 1 April 1990

Christy & Mary Smith, 9 September 2001

Finding Eileen

Meanwhile, Mary believing there might be a chance her mother was still alive, wants to visit the Magdalene Laundry at Sunday's Wells and persuades Joan to go there with her. They speak to a nun at Sunday's Well, and Mary is told to return in an hour. Upon her return, the nun produces an admission paper that shows her mother, Eileen, had been admitted to Our Lady's Mental Asylum on Lee Road in Co. Cork.

Mary insisted she wanted to visit Our Lady's to find out more about her mother's death and Joan and Mary visited the asylum together. A staff member eventually confirms that Eileen Smith had indeed been a patient there, brought in by William Callaghan and that her mother had died there in 1964 at the age of 42. Mary was informed that her mother had been buried in a mass grave.

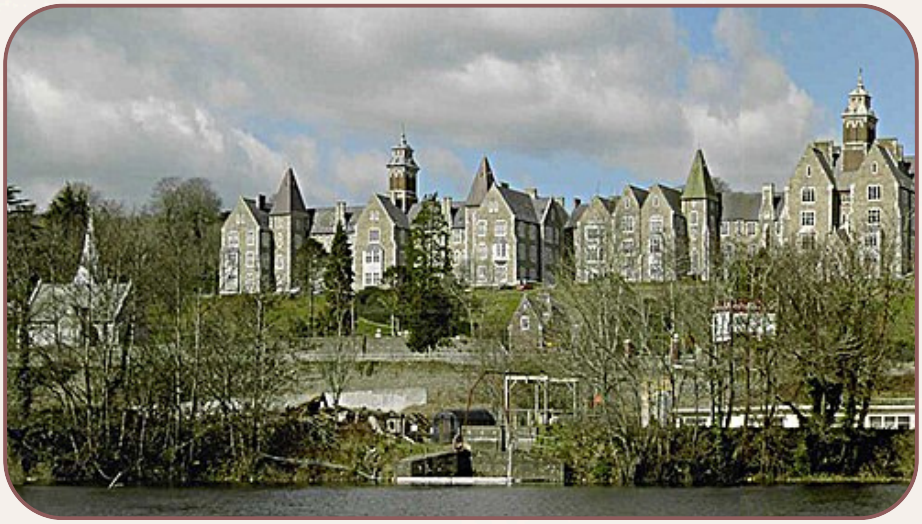
When Mary eventually locates the grave, she spends several hours just sitting by the grave site trying to make sense of all that had gone before her. She didn't want to leave the grave, and recalls how she felt a deep feeling of just wanting to die, to be with her mother.

In Loving Memory of Residents of the Magdalene Laundry, Sunday's Wells

Remembering Christy

Christopher Smith, affectionately called Christy, was born on 6 July 1946. His mother Eileen gave birth to him while sentenced to Bessborough Mother and Baby Home in Blackrock, Cork, run by the Sisters of the Sacred Hearts of Jesus and Mary. Her crime was being an unmarried mother.

Eileen and Christy remained there for approximately three years until Mary's grandmother succeeded in having them released.



When Eileen became pregnant with Mary in 1952, Christy was taken from his mother at the age of six years old, and court ordered to Greenmount Industrial School and later to Upton Industrial School in Co. Cork.

Christy later confided to Mary the names of two Christian Brothers in Upton who had sexually abused him. Christy spent a total of 10 years in Upton until age 16, at which time he was sent to work as a farm labourer at Humphries Farm and remained there until he was 18 years old.

After Humphries Farm, with no family or home to go to, Christy was sent to work with another priest in Kilbritton. He was there for one week, when he reports having been raped by another priest. It is not known if the priest was ever investigated, but Christy having fled the farm, was found and brought by the Guards to Our Lady's Mental Asylum on Lee Road in Cork. He later tells Mary the reason he was sent to the Mental Asylum was because there was no home for him to go to, and the authorities didn't want trouble for the priest.

18 March 2006, A big change in Christopher, his deterioration begins to show

28 December 2006, Mary still trying to save Christopher's life, feels Christopher is at death's door

In 1965, Christy attempted to leave Our Lady's Mental Hospital and signed himself out of the Asylum, but 10 months later he was found unable to cope without any life skills, he was wandering the streets of Cork, with no fixed abode and hungry, he was brought back to the mental asylum. It's important to note, that Christy was never diagnosed with a mental illness, or charged with a crime, or involuntarily committed, his only crime was forced abandonment, homelessness and reporting the alleged rapes. Christy was sentenced to the Industrial Schools from the age of six, incarcerated in mental asylums at the age of 18 and would remain incarcerated for the rest of his life, until his death in February 2007 at the age of 60.

2 January 2007, Christopher is taken to Unit 5 Lock Up ward, his condition deteriorating. Mary believes her brother is on death row

20 January 2007, Christopher in agony, Mary concerned he is dying. His condition continues to deteriorate

Human Rights Violations

Encounters With Psychiatrist Eugene Morgan

Eugene Morgan, was the psychiatrist responsible for the care of Christopher Smith since 1978. When Mary first discovered the whereabouts of Christy in 1998, she was told Christy had withdrawn into himself since the previous decade. When she first met Morgan, he attempted to brush her off by dismissing her and even ordered her to leave the hospital. All further attempts to get Morgan to release Christy were refused and dismissed.

For the next 9 years, from 1998 to Christy's death in February 2007, Mary would travel weekly to visit Christy. The journey was arduous; leaving Dublin at 9:30am, arriving to see Christy by noon, visit Christy until 4:00pm then return to Dublin late evening.

After 3 months, when news of Our Lady's was closing down, Christy was transferred to St. Stephen's psychiatric hospital, in Glanmire. Eugene Morgan continued as psychiatrist over Christy's care. During this time, Mary stepped up her campaign to get Christy released.

13 january 2007, Christopher has a large head injury, appears to have his head split open. Christopher not allowed into the hospital, not allowed food

20 November 2006,

20 November 2006

Christopher's condition worsening

Mary had contacted Patricia Daly, an American social worker working in a hospital on Baggot Street in Dublin. Mary asked Patricia for help to get Christy released. Patricia informed Mary that she had tried everything possible to get Christy released but Eugene Morgan was saying he wouldn't let Christy go because Christy was being sexually active with "everybody" he saw.

Mary challenged Morgan on this, stating that in the 20 years since Morgan had taken over Christy's case in 1978, Christy had been so heavily drugged that he had 'gone inside himself' and was incapable of any sexual activity. Mary also pointed out that there was not any shed of evidence or one single complaint made against Christy of him ever sexually abusing anyone. She argued, that the reasons for keeping her brother locked up were false and accused Morgan of being an out-and-out bully.

2 January 2007

During Mary's visits with Christy, he frequently begged Mary to help him leave the institution and Morgan always refused to allow Christy to leave. Christopher is taken to Unit 5 Lock Up ward, his condition deteriorating

Brutalities in the Asylum

Over the years, Mary witnessed a litany of disturbing physical and mental abuse by staff and psychiatrist Eugene Morgan. On one occasion, two employees whom she recalls as Nicholas Brown and John O'Driscoll, had physically dragged Christy down a corridor to forcibly administer an injection against Christy's will after he had refused the drug.

On one visit, Mary observed Christy could no longer read a clock, and an optician later confirmed that he had developed advanced cataracts that had not been treated by the hospital staff.

On another visit, Christy was doubled over with terrible pains in his stomach, in despair, Mary called an ambulance, but the ambulance was refused and denied to come to Christy's aid.

And another visit, Mary found Christy lying on the floor, he was unable to get up. He was drugged 'out of his mind.' His physical condition had deteriorated dramatically and he was becoming extremely thin and appeared to be wasting away despite having no terminal illness diagnosed.

Mary became increasingly concerned about Christy's physical and mental condition and reports Eugene Morgan to the Medical Council. An investigation for malpractice and maltreatment of her brother was started but that investigation went nowhere and Morgan walked free. In retaliation, the abuse against Christy increased. Morgan knew Mary had no help or family, and Mary believes that's why Morgan refused to release Christy into her care.

Mary attempts to pursue legal action and reports the matter to the Irish Garda. Although detectives begin investigating, she later learned that a well-connected state solicitor, John Brosnan, contacted the Director of Public Prosecutions advising them that no prosecution should be brought.

13 January 2007

13 January 2007

By January 2007, Christy's health had deteriorated significantly. Without any explanation he is moved to the highest security lock up - Unit 5, despite being severely malnourished and needing urgent medical care. No medical treatment is provided. Christy's weight had gone from 150 lbs to seriously malnutritioned.

13 January 2007, Mary discovered and later confirmed by CT Scans and medical records that Christy suffered a head injury, where his head had been split open and he had suffered a head trauma.

20 January 2007, Christopher is in agony, Mary is concerned he is dying. His condition continues to deteriorating rapidly.

On the night of 15th February 2007, Mary phoned Christy. He was struggling with his breathing, he could hardly speak or get his breath. Mary begged Peter Jackson, the staff member on duty that night, to please get Christy an ambulance. Jackson was disinterested and refused. Anthony Finn, Mary's friend, witnessed the call, he grabs the phone ordering Jackson to get Christopher an Ambulance. The staff member's response, "I can't wave a magic wand!"

The last words from Christy said to Mary that night: "*There is no God. All I did was Suffer, Suffer and Suffer from Praying, Praying and Praying.*"

16 February 2007

Christopher 'Christy' Smith is found dead in his room.

Never Forgotten

"My brother was locked up and drugged for 40 years. He was never certified or committed" - Mary Smith

Despite repeated attempts to obtain help from different authorities to release Christy and bring accountability, Mary Smith has largely fought alone.

As of 2026, psychiatrist Eugene Morgan still practices psychiatry in the prison system in Co Cork.

There has been no accountability for the deaths of her mother Eileen or brother Christy Smith.

There has been no information forthcoming on Eileen's death or how she came to be in a mass grave.

Never Forgotten

"THERE IS NO GOD. ALL I DID WAS SUFFER, SUFFER AND SUFFER, FROM PRAYING, PRAYING AND PRAYING."

— CHRISTOPHER (CHRISTY) SMITH

15 FEBRUARY 2007

Christy Smith

6 JULY 1946 - 16 FEBRUARY 2007

In Loving Memory

16 February 2007
Christopher found dead in his room

"Their stories will not be silenced.
Their lives will not be forgotten."

Mary Smith, 2026